

The eagle has flown



A Carolina Raptor Center worker releases Washington, the rehabilitated eagle.

Ric Carter photo

Injured bird returned to the wild

By Megan Schnabel
Staff Writer

It was one of those brief, tremulous alliances between man and nature. Although brought about through man's carelessness, the few short months of contact between humans and eagle proved coexistence to be possible for the benefit of both.

Washington, the eagle with the president's name, was freed last Sunday at Lake Mattamuskeet, six months after he was first carried from that site to enter rehabilitation in the care of a handful of humans.

The encounter began in late January at the Mattamuskeet National Wildlife

Refuge near Swan Quarter when Glenn Price, a refuge staff member, came upon a bald eagle sitting on a small island in shallow water.

Instead of flying off as the human neared, the eagle only managed to walk around, obviously injured.

"It had a hurt wing," said Barry Jordan, refuge officer. "We later found out it was caused by a gunshot."

After a short struggle, Jordan and Price managed to capture the bird and transported him to Washington's Pamlico Animal Hospital for an examination. Dr. Dana Eddings, a veterinarian at the hospital, checked out the extent of the eagle's injuries.

"He'd been gunshot through the wing,

and it fractured several of the bones in his wing," Eddings said. "Lead from the bullet was visible in the x-rays."

Because the fracture appeared to be one that would heal quite well by itself, Eddings splinted and banded the wing.

"When we get injured birds like this, I do the initial treatment," Eddings said. The hospital doesn't have the staff or facilities for rehabilitation, however, and so following treatment, Eddings sends birds of prey to Charlotte's Carolina Raptor Center, where injured and sick birds of prey are nursed back to health by a staff of full-time employees and

volunteers.

That's where Mathias Engelmann first laid eyes on the eagle, named Washington by Raptor Center staff in honor of Eddings' home town.

"It was emaciated," Engelmann said. "But it was fairly alert. It actually did quite well for an injured bird. It was alert and defensive."

And in need of help from kind human hands. Engelmann said the bird was given antibiotics twice a day, and vitamins and calcium supplements were mixed into Washington's food, a tasty concoction of fish and rats.

It took three to four weeks for the fractured bone to heal, Engelmann said. Staff members and volunteers

kept the wound cleaned and banded, awaiting the day when Washington would be ready for exercise.

Physical therapy, usually thought of as something for human patients, was employed in the eagle's rehabilitation as well. Every few days, Engelmann said, the wing would be unbanded and the eagle put through therapy to prevent his joints from freezing up.

"We exercised the wing for the bird very carefully," Engelmann said. As the bird grew stronger and more limber, aggressiveness soon followed. Washington had to be moved outside, away from the other birds caged inside, because of his aggressive behavior.

Washington's healing was well under way after five to six weeks of constant care and therapy, Engelmann said. The bird soon began exercising on his own, stretching his wings cautiously.

"In the meantime, we were working on building a flight cage," Engelmann said. Nothing at the center was large enough to accommodate Washington, with his 6- to 6½-foot wingspan, as he prepared to take to the air again.

A 96-foot flight cage, paid for with \$4,500 donated by area businesses and individuals, was constructed with volunteer labor.

"That was a big step," Engelmann said. "We could exercise the bird without a lot of stress to it." He said they made the bird fly back and forth repeatedly, strengthening his muscles, which had begun to atrophy from lack of use.

Finally, nearly six months after Washington's arrival in Charlotte, he was ready for release into the wild. Center workers prepared to drive him back to Mattamuskeet for his flight to freedom.

"That's one of the few spots in North Carolina with an adequate food supply," Engelmann said. He added that eagles, being social creatures, tended to congregate at the refuge, another factor influencing the decision to return Washington to the scene of his capture.

The long-awaited release came on July 26.

"It's kind of scary," Engelmann

said of releasing animals back into the wild. "We never know for sure if everything's going to go O.K. Personally, I'm always a little bit — more than a little bit — nervous. But it's a good feeling. You know you've made a difference in this bird's life."

"They let him go, and he just took off and flew and flew and flew," said Heather Bolte, a volunteer at the refuge. "As we were driving away later, we saw him flying. He did what he was supposed to do."

Ms. Bolte thinks Washington may hang around the refuge because that's where he was found. "I was out doing my work and saw it flying around on Monday," she said.

Jordan said he enjoys caring for the injured birds that are brought to the refuge, but "you hate to see it." Eddings, too, is upset by senseless

shootings of endangered animals.

"You have to hope as time goes on that people are learning not to shoot them," Eddings said. But he thinks some shootings, although punishable by steep fines and prison terms, may be the result of the misconception that birds of prey exhaust supplies of game birds.

Eddings said he believes there was no way Washington could have been mistaken for a game bird and shot accidentally. "No sportsman who knew what he was shooting at" could have thought the eagle was a goose or swan, Eddings said.

The purpose of the Carolina Raptor Center, which derives its name from the Latin word meaning "to grab" or "to seize," is to educate the public about birds of prey so that incidents like this become less and less frequent.

"Rehab was the early goal, the single goal" of the center when it was incorporated in 1980, Engelmann said. Very soon, education became even more important.

Engelmann and his colleagues at the center travel across the state, and even to neighboring states, presenting educational programs using birds kept at the center.

"Education is where we think the future lies for these birds and for ourselves," Engelmann said. "You can do rehab until you're blue in the face, but you must understand the natural balance."

Eagle From Page 1A